

January

3



1868

The Meiji Restoration

Emperor Meiji announced that Japan was back under the direct rule of the emperor, after almost seven centuries of control by warlords known as shoguns.

Born this day

1892 J R R Tolkien, British author. His most popular books, *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*, are set in Middle-earth, a fantasy world of his own creation.

Also on this day

1925 Political leader Benito Mussolini became dictator of Italy, announcing that he would rule by force if necessary.

1957 The first electric watch, the Hamilton Electric 500, was launched in the USA. It was unreliable, constantly requiring new batteries.

2019 A lander successfully touched down on the far side of the Moon for the first time, as part of the Chinese mission Chang'e 4.

1888

Drinking straw

US inventor Marvin Stone received a patent for his invention of an artificial straw made by twisting paper into the shape of a tube. He was fed up with ryegrass straws spoiling the taste of his drinks.



The rights of women

British writer and early champion of women's rights Mary Wollstonecraft finished *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*, a book in which she argued that women are equal to men, and deserve the same rights to a full education.

1792

